

## CORE FORMULA

**Formula:** notice shared context -> name it simply -> add an easy entry point -> pause -> follow the thread they choose. -> **Social:** "Looks like we both ended up in the quieter corner. I am Sam." -> **Meeting:** "The shared question today is whether we narrow the scope or move the date." -> **Clinical:** "I have read the referral, but I would rather start with what feels most important from your side." -> **Re-entry:** "Last time Friday was the pressure point. Is that still the right place to start?" -> **Digital:** "Context first: I am writing because the decision point has moved closer."

## MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Name the shared context in one ordinary line, then give the other person an easy way to enter: "Looks like we are both waiting for the same session. I am Sam."

## BEST FOR

- Meeting someone for the first time.
- A direct personal question would feel abrupt.
- You share a room, queue, event, task, deadline or mutual problem.
- The other person looks socially cautious or busy.
- Starting a meeting with focus rather than vague pleasantries.
- Opening a clinical-style, client or supervision conversation.
- Returning to a conversation after time has passed.
- Sending a cold message that needs to explain why it exists.

## PHRASE BANK

### Shared setting / immediate context · Short observational one-liners

- "Looks like we both picked the busy time."
- "Seems like we are both waiting on the same thing."
- "This is a quieter corner than the main room."
- "That session pulled a lot of people in."
- "We have landed in the same queue."
- "The room has that pre-meeting energy."

### Waiting / event / social opener · Social rapport at events and queues

- "Have you been to one of these before, or is this your first time too?"
- "What brought you to this session?"
- "Did you come for a particular talk, or just to see what was useful?"
- "That last speaker gave us a lot to think about."
- "Looks like we have a few minutes before it starts."
- "The schedule is packed. Which part are you here for?"

### Task / meeting opener · Naming the shared work

- "Before we get into the detail, the main thing today is to align on the next step."
- "I know we have limited time, so I will start with the context."
- "This seems like the right moment to separate what is urgent from what is important."
- "Before we solve it, can I quickly name what I think the situation is?"
- "It sounds like the handover is the shared pressure point."
- "The context I am bringing in is that the deadline has moved closer."

### Professional / client / clinical-style · Orienting before questions

- "Before we start, I know there can be a lot of admin around this. I will keep the opening brief."
- "I have read the referral, but I would rather hear what feels most important from your side."
- "Before I ask questions, I want to orient to what today is meant to help with."
- "Let us start with what made today feel worth booking."
- "The paperwork gives one version. I want to understand the lived version."
- "We can go at a practical pace. Where would it be easiest to start?"

### Group opener · Naming common ground before divergence

- "Before we go around the room, I want to name what we are here to decide."
- "The shared context is that everyone is carrying part of the load."
- "There are a few perspectives here, so I will first name the common ground."
- "We are not trying to solve the whole system today. We are choosing the next useful move."
- "Before we debate options, let us agree what situation we are responding to."
- "I want to start with the shared aim rather than the loudest problem."

### Time / transition opener · Marking a shift or restart

- "Coming back after a break can be a bit clunky. Where did we leave it?"
- "Since we last spoke, one thing has changed."
- "This is probably a good point to reset the frame."
- "We have shifted from options to decisions."
- "The timing matters here because the next step affects the rest of the week."
- "This feels like a transition from exploring to choosing."

### Re-entry / follow-up · Reconnecting to the last thread

- "Last time we were mainly talking about capacity. Is that still the right starting point?"
- "I remember you were waiting on a decision. Did that land yet?"
- "Since our last conversation, what has moved and what has stayed stuck?"
- "I want to reconnect with the main thing rather than restart from scratch."
- "The last thread was about whether this felt workable. Where is it now?"
- "The detail I remember is that Friday was the pressure point. Is that still true?"

### Digital / text · Context first in writing

- "Picking this up from your message about Friday."
- "Context first: I am writing with the deadline in mind."
- "Before the details, the shared issue seems to be timing."
- "This might be easier if I separate the context from the ask."
- "The reason I am messaging now is that the decision point has moved closer."
- "Coming back to the part about scope..."

## WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: So, what is your story?  
Better: What brought you here?  
**Best: This session seems to have pulled in a mixed group. What brought you to this one?**
2. Weak: Tell me why you are here.  
Better: What brings you in today?  
**Best: I have read the referral, but I would rather start with what feels most important from your side.**
3. Weak: We need to talk.  
Better: Can we talk about what happened yesterday?  
**Best: I want to pick up yesterday while it is still fresh, especially the point where the handover broke down.**
4. Weak: Hi.  
Better: Hi, I am Alex.  
**Best: Looks like we are both waiting for the same workshop. I am Alex.**

## DECISION TREE

### If You are entering a new interaction

Name the shared situation before asking a personal or broad question.

*"Looks like we are both here for the same session. I am Sam."*

### If The other person looks busy

Acknowledge the constraint and keep the ask small.

*"I can see you are between things — this is a two-minute question."*

### If The meeting needs focus

Use a purpose opener rather than a social warm-up.

*"The shared question today is whether we narrow the scope or move the date."*

### If You have prior context

Reference one remembered detail or the last thread before asking what has changed.

*"Last time Friday was the pressure point. Is that still true?"*

### If The opening feels awkward

Recover by simplifying — name the real reason plainly.

*"Let me say that more plainly."*

### If The conversation is already open

Stop opening. Move to listening, summary, or the next practical step.

## SCENARIOS

### First meeting

Name the shared setting and make entry easy. — *"Looks like we are both waiting for the same session. I am Sam."*

### Clinic or client opening

Orient to the process before asking personal questions. — *"I have read the referral, but I would rather hear what feels most important from your side."*

### Hallway interruption

Name the immediate constraint. — *"I can see you are between things. This is a two-minute question about Friday."*

### Networking event

Use the event as the bridge. — *"That talk had a lot in it. What part did you come for?"*

### Re-entry after a gap

Reconnect to the last live thread. — *"Last time the pressure point was scope. Is that still the right starting place?"*

### Conflict repair

Name the shared event without prosecuting it. — *"I want to pick up yesterday, especially the point where the tone changed."*

## WHEN NOT TO USE

- The context is not actually shared.
- The situation calls for direct action rather than social entry.
- The person is clearly unavailable, distressed, time-pressured or needing privacy.
- The shared context is sensitive and you cannot name it respectfully.
- You already have an established conversation and another opener would feel redundant.
- You cannot follow up with genuine attention.
- Physical safety or an immediate emergency takes priority.

## 7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

### Day 1 — Spot the context

For one day, silently notice a possible opener in each new interaction. Label each as setting, task, timing, constraint, event or prior thread — without using any of them yet.

### **Day 2 — List your abrupt starts**

Write down five situations where you tend to start too abruptly, such as "Can I ask you something?", "We need to talk", or "Tell me about yourself."

### **Day 3 — Name the shared context**

For each of those five, write one true shared context — the setting, task, timing, constraint or previous thread you could name instead.

### **Day 4 — Turn context into openers**

Turn each shared context into a single-sentence opener, then add one easy entry point so the other person can step in.

### **Day 5 — Cut the clever**

Read each opener aloud and remove anything clever, too personal or overexplained until it sounds like plain orientation to the moment.

### **Day 6 — Use one for real**

In a low-stakes interaction, use one contextual opener, then stop and follow whatever thread they give you rather than your planned line.

### **Day 7 — Three in a day**

Use three contextual openers — one social, one professional, one written — and afterwards ask of each: did I make entry easier, or did I make them manage my opener?

## **AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST**

- Did I name a context that was actually shared?
- Was the observation safe to name?
- Did the opener sound ordinary rather than scripted?
- Did I give the other person an easy entry point?
- Did I stop after the door opened, and follow their thread instead of mine?
- Did I move to purpose when the situation needed directness rather than warm-up?